

Zara Ahmed

Product Leader / Founder (fintech)

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SUMMARY

Founder and product lead of Paisly, an Account Aggregator-based budgeting app that grew to 60k users before shutting down in 2025 when our Series A fell through. Three years of zero-to-one product work on India's open-finance rails, on top of a UX research background. I have made every product mistake once and am looking to bring the scar tissue to a team with distribution.

SKILLS

Product: Zero-to-one discovery, rapid prototyping, growth loops, retention analysis (Amplitude), pricing experiments, app-store optimization

Domain: Account Aggregator integration (via an AA TSP), transaction categorization for Indian bank feeds, budgeting UX, DPDP-compliant data handling

Research: User interviews (400+ logged), usability testing, survey design

EXPERIENCE

Co-founder & Head of Product — Paisly (budgeting app), Bengaluru

Mar 2022 – Nov 2025

- Built and launched an AA-based budgeting app; 60k registered users, 22k MAU at peak, 4.5 Play Store rating.
- Ran the full product loop solo: discovery, specs, analytics (Amplitude), releases with a 5-person eng team.
- Improved 90-day retention from 8% to 27% over six iterations of the categorization and insights features.
- Raised Rs. 7.5 crore in seed funding; shut the company down responsibly (user data migration window, DPDP-clean deletion) when Series A failed.

UX Researcher — Quotient Labs (SaaS), Bengaluru

Jan 2019 – Feb 2022

- Research for fintech and retail clients; built the company's usability-testing practice.

EDUCATION

M.Des Interaction Design — IDC School of Design, IIT Bombay, 2016 – 2018

B.Tech Information Technology — Jamia Millia Islamia, New Delhi, 2012 – 2016

SPEAKING

"Post-mortem of a fintech startup" — ProductTank Bengaluru, March 2026 (150 attendees)

LANGUAGES KNOWN

Urdu (native), Hindi (fluent), English (fluent), Kannada (basic)